



AU REVOIR: Sarkozy with Patil and Manmohan at Rashtrapati Bhavan

thing on the agenda was civilian nuclear cooperation. Keen to capitalise on its first mover advantage—French nuclear giants like Areva have already made a place for themselves here—France is looking forward to selling civilian nuclear reactors to India. Sarkozy also endorsed India's aspirations to be on the global high table as a permanent member of the UN Security Council and in an expanded G-13.

As he watched the military parade, Sarkozy pondered over how to bag a bigger share in one of the world's biggest defence equipment purchases for the next decade, worth \$30 billion (Rs 1,200 crore). When he met Manmohan, Sarkozy was candid in his disappointment at the scrapping of the Eurocopter deal. "We have some difficulties in entering the Indian defence market," he said. The two agreed to remove the irritants and double the current level of bilateral trade from €6.3 billion to €12 billion by 2012. In the sphere of defence, the focus will be on joint research and development projects, transfer of technology and military exchanges. An agreement on mutual protection of classified information and security was also inked.

Sarkozy, the former interior minister of the Chirac government, who is battling religious fundamentalism at home, stressed on security cooperation with India. The two leaders agreed on greater cooperation between intelligence agencies. Surprisingly at ease, Sarkozy was eager on taking the bilateral talks forward. When Manmohan, who will be in France later this year for the Indo-EU summit, expressed concern about Sikh students not being allowed to wear turbans to school in France, Sarkozy replied that he would look into it. He gently nodded when Singh raised the issue of relaxation of visa norms for businessmen, professionals and students. The French President's visit achieved the purpose of imparting a focused approach to the strategic relationship.

Sarkozy, known to be passionate about whatever he pursues, signed off his visit with the promise that building a global partnership with India will be one of his "passions" in the year ahead.

by Saurabh Shukla

The New Best Friend

The flamboyant French President shunned protocol and won over his hosts with his willingness to go the extra mile for India

Not many chief guests have aroused as much excitement as French President Nicolas Sarkozy did when he was in Delhi for the Republic Day celebrations. The 53-year-old lawyer-turned-politician lived up to his reputation for flamboyance, and along with style, brought plenty of substance to his visit. Though his girlfriend Carla Bruni was missed—till the last minute there was intense speculation that she may actually join him at the Taj Mahal—Sarkozy seemed smitten by Shah Jahan's monumental expression of love, and wrote in the visitors' book, "I will be back". Perhaps with Bruni in the near future.

Sarkozy gave anxious moments to protocol officials when he kept President Pratibha Patil and other dignitaries waiting at the reception hosted by her. A day earlier, he had jocularly quizzed officials if he would have to watch camels and horses from Rajasthan for two hours during the parade. That was true to form. When a delegation of Indian CEOs had called on him at the Elysee Palace before he

left for India, an Indian businessman had suggested that Bruni could be a model for his company's campaign. The President promptly called her up about the assignment.

To his hosts in India, he came across as a politician who values the position of India in the global diplomatic sweepstakes. Speaking through an interpreter and occasionally in English, he reiterated that Paris was Delhi's best friend. "This is a strategic partnership; the sky is the limit," he told Prime Minister Manmohan Singh after their summit-level talks. The first

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- Supports India for a permanent membership at the UN Security Council and at the expanded G-13
- Bilateral trade target set at €12 billion from the current €6.3 billion by 2012
- People-to-people exchanges to grow
- Push for India-specific exemption at the Nuclear Suppliers Group